

HOUSEWORK GETS YOU DOWN

A Pre-Reading Lead-In Lesson | B2-C1 | Standalone

LESSON FOCUS & AIMS

The lesson activates and extends emotional vocabulary around domestic life through discussion and first-person reading, preparing students to engage critically with the coursebook text on page 30.

Aims:

- To activate the student's existing language around domestic tasks and emotional responses to them
- To expose the student to 17 target and support vocabulary items in natural, spoken-register contexts
- To develop close-reading and interpretive skills through comprehension questions focused on emotional register
- To create a smooth, motivated entry point into the coursebook reading text

STAGE 1 -- OPENING DISCUSSION | ~10 minutes

Teacher note: Allow 10 minutes for this stage. Keep the atmosphere genuinely conversational -- this is not a test and not a vocabulary exercise. Watch whether the student engages freely or monitors their language carefully; the former is the goal. Listen for the emotional vocabulary they already have around domestic tasks -- this is useful diagnostic information for Stage 2. Keep the pressure off entirely; the discussion questions are an opener, not a performance.

STUDENT INSTRUCTION

Talk about these questions. There are no right or wrong answers -- just say what you think and feel.

1. Is there a household task you genuinely don't mind doing? What is it about that one task that makes it different from the others?
2. Do you think your attitude toward housework has changed over the years? What do you think caused the change, if there was one?
3. Some people say a clean home makes them feel calmer. Others say they barely notice. Where do you stand?
4. Have you ever felt resentful about doing a household task -- not just tired, but genuinely unfair? What was the situation?
5. If someone offered to take one household task off your hands permanently, which one would you choose, and why that one?

ICQS

ICQ Are you going to write your answers, or just talk about them?

Expected: Just talk

ICQ Is there a right or wrong answer to any of these questions?

Expected: No

STAGE 2 -- FIVE VOICES | ~25 minutes

Teacher note: Allow approximately 25 minutes for this stage -- roughly 5 minutes per speaker, including discussion time. Do not pre-teach vocabulary. The goal is for the student to encounter each word or phrase in context and then discuss what it carries emotionally and socially. After the student reads each monologue, pose the comprehension questions orally and let the discussion breathe. Listen for whether the student is engaging with the emotional register of the vocabulary or merely paraphrasing the content -- the former is the target.

STUDENT INSTRUCTION

Read what five different people say about housework. After each one, we'll talk about what they said.

Speaker -- Darnell

I don't know, it kind of came as a surprise to me, honestly -- the way I actually feel about it now. Like when I was in my twenties I would just... not do it. I mean, I'd do it eventually, but only when things had reached a point that was just -- okay, this is unacceptable. And now I'm in my forties and something has shifted. I'm not going to pretend the dishes make me happy. But there's this thing that happens when the kitchen is spotless -- just, like, genuinely spotless, nothing on the counter, everything where it belongs -- and I walk in there in the morning, and I feel... settled. I don't know how else to put it. Settled. My wife laughs at me. She says I've undergone a personality change. I tell her it's not my personality -- it's just that I finally understand the connection between the space around me and the state of my head.

Think It Through

Q1 (Short answer) Darnell says the kitchen being spotless makes him feel "settled." Based on everything he says, what do you think the word spotless carries for him -- is it just about cleanliness, or is there something else underneath it?

Teacher tip: Wait after asking. This question asks the student to read between the lines -- they need to synthesise what Darnell says about his twenties with what he says now. If they move to answer quickly and stay on the surface ("it means very clean"), hold space: resist affirming that response. Let a pause do the work.

If the student struggles: Ask: "He says he feels 'settled' when the kitchen is spotless. What's the opposite of settled? And what does that tell us about why the word matters to him?"

Q2 (Multiple choice) Darnell says he has "undergone a change." Which of the following best describes what kind of change he means?

- a) A sudden decision he made one day
- b) A gradual shift in what he values and notices**
- c) A change he consciously decided to make after noticing how he felt
- d) A change he resists and feels confused by

Expected answer: b

Teacher tip: Notice whether the student reads the options carefully or picks quickly. If they pick quickly, let them commit to their answer and then ask: "What in the text supports that?" -- rather than signalling whether they are right.

If the student struggles: Ask: "Did he say it happened all at once, or slowly? And did he choose it, or did it just... happen to him?"

Q3 (Short answer) Darnell says he used to "not do it" and now he does. But he doesn't say he enjoys it. What does this tell you about what the phrase to undergo a change means -- does it always mean becoming happy about something?

Teacher tip: This is the counter-example question for this set -- it pushes the student to draw a boundary around the concept. Let them sit with it. Resist the urge to rephrase too quickly.

If the student struggles: Ask: "Can someone change how they behave without changing how they feel? Is Darnell happy about cleaning, or just... different about it?"

Speaker -- Priscilla

Okay, so according to my therapist, my whole thing with housework is tied up with control. Which, I mean -- she's probably right, I'm not going to argue. But what she doesn't fully get is that when things feel chaotic in other areas of my life, having a clean flat isn't just nice -- it's functional. It does something. It's not the same as being a neat freak or whatever. It's more like... if everything else is falling apart, at least this one thing makes sense. Something about that makes sense to me in a way I can't entirely explain. The irony is that my flatmate is completely the opposite. She genuinely doesn't seem to see the mess at all. And I'm not going to pretend that doesn't intensify my negative feelings about coming home some days -- because it does. It really does.

What's Really Going On?

Q1 (Short answer) Priscilla says "this one thing makes sense" when she's feeling chaotic. What does she mean when she uses the phrase makes sense here -- is she talking about logic, or something closer to comfort?

Teacher tip: This question asks the student to distinguish between two valid meanings of the same phrase in context. Wait for their interpretation before reacting. Both "logic" and "comfort" may be partly right -- the interesting answer is the one that holds both.

If the student struggles: Ask: "If her flat being clean were purely logical, why would she need a therapist to explain it to her? What's the difference between something being logical and something feeling right?"

Q2 (Multiple choice) When Priscilla says her flatmate's behaviour "intensifies her negative feelings," what does this tell us about the word intensify?

- a) It means the feelings appear for the first time because of the flatmate
- b) It means the feelings were already there and become stronger**
- c) It means the feelings change from negative to something more complicated
- d) It means the feelings are directed specifically at the flatmate

Expected answer: b

Teacher tip: Notice if the student hesitates between b and d -- this is a productive confusion. If they choose d, ask: "Is she angry at her flatmate, or does she just feel worse when she gets home? Are those the same thing?"

If the student struggles: Ask: "Before she comes home, does she already have negative feelings about something? And what does the mess do to those feelings -- start them, or add to them?"

Q3 (Short answer) Priscilla says "according to my therapist" rather than just "my therapist says." What feeling does the phrase according to carry when she uses it here -- does she fully believe what her therapist thinks?

Teacher tip: This is a precision question about register and stance. Let the student sit with it -- they may not have noticed the phrase consciously when they read it. Resist paraphrasing the question. Let them go back to the text if they want to.

If the student struggles: Ask: "If she agreed completely with her therapist, would she say 'according to her' -- or something different? Try both and see what changes."

Speaker -- Waverly

I went through a period -- this was maybe three years ago -- where I no longer did any of it. Like, zero. My partner did everything. And I think the thing I didn't expect was how much that bothered me. Not the mess, not the relationship stuff -- just the feeling that something had been taken off me without my choosing it. Like, I hadn't asked for that arrangement. It had just... solidified. And I remember thinking: this isn't a break, this is just... I've opted out of my own home somehow. The weird thing is, my partner -- he actually, genuinely, finds it calming, I think. Or at least he never seems to mind it. But I couldn't shake this feeling of being a guest in my own space. So I -- slowly, kind of awkwardly -- started doing things again. Not swiftly, not all at once. Just a dish here, a surface there. And that feeling of being a guest started to lift.

Look Again

Q1 (Multiple choice) Waverly says a burden "was taken off" them. But they didn't feel relieved -- they felt uncomfortable. Which of the following best explains why?

- a) They felt guilty that their partner was doing more work
- b) The arrangement happened passively, without their choice or agreement**
- c) They missed the feeling of having a clean home
- d) Their partner was resentful about doing all the housework

Expected answer: b

Teacher tip: This question tests whether the student has understood the emotional centre of Waverly's story. If they choose a, ask: "Does Waverly say they felt guilty? What word do they actually use?" Let the text settle the question.

If the student struggles: Ask: "Did Waverly decide to stop doing housework, or did it just happen? And why does that difference matter to how they felt?"

Q2 (Short answer) Waverly says they started doing housework again "not swiftly, not all at once." What does the word swiftly tell us about the process of coming back to something you've stepped away from -- is a slow return a weak one?

Teacher tip: This question asks the student to read swiftly against its context -- its negation here is meaningful. Let them work with the contrast. Resist offering the insight that negating a word can emphasise a quality rather than deny it -- let the student arrive there.

If the student struggles: Ask: "If they came back slowly, does that mean they weren't sure they wanted to? Or could a slow return mean something else about how careful they were being?"

Q3 (Short answer) Waverly says they "no longer did any of it" during that period. What does the phrase to no longer do something suggest about the timeline -- does it imply they stopped suddenly, or gradually?

Teacher tip: Hold the question open. This is partly a language precision question and partly an invitation to look at how Waverly describes the whole arc of that period. Both readings may be defensible -- let the student make a case.

If the student struggles: Ask: "Think about the phrase 'I no longer smoke.' Does that tell you when or how the person stopped -- or just that they have stopped? What does that do to our understanding of Waverly's situation?"

Speaker -- Soren

I'll be honest with you -- the thing that makes me most miserable isn't the cleaning itself. It's the planning of it. You know? My family growing up was very... structured. Very deaf to objection. Saturday morning, everyone cleaned, no discussion, no negotiation. And I think I

absorbed that, like, okay, cleanliness requires strategic planning, it requires a schedule, it requires this whole system. And now I'm an adult living alone and I still feel this thing every Friday evening where I'm like -- okay, tomorrow is the day. And then Saturday comes and I just... don't have the will. I open the cupboard, I look at the cleaning products, and something in me just completely deflates. I've talked to friends who clean enthusiastically -- they just grab something and start, no ceremony, no buildup. And I genuinely envy that. The spontaneity of it. For me, the weight of the ritual makes me miserable before I've even started.

Does It Add Up?

Q1 (Short answer) Soren says his family was "deaf to objection" about housework. What does this phrase suggest about the emotional atmosphere around housework in his childhood -- and do you think it still affects him now?

Teacher tip: This is an inferential question with two parts -- let the student take one at a time if they need to. Resist breaking the question down yourself unless they genuinely stall on both parts. The connection between childhood and the present is the insight the question is designed to surface.

If the student struggles: Ask: "If nobody listens to your objections as a child, what happens to those feelings -- do they disappear, or do they go somewhere?"

Q2 (Multiple choice) Soren says he "doesn't have the will" on Saturday mornings. What does this phrase tell us?

- a) He is physically too tired to clean
- b) He has decided not to clean as a form of protest
- c) The desire or internal motivation simply isn't there**
- d) He has too many other things to do

Expected answer: c

Teacher tip: Notice if the student chooses a -- fatigue is a tempting interpretation. If they do, ask: "He says he opens the cupboard and looks at the cleaning products -- does that sound like someone who's too tired to start, or someone who's ready to start but something stops them?"

If the student struggles: Ask: "Does Soren want to clean on Saturday? And is 'not wanting to' the same as 'not having the will'? Try putting the phrase into a sentence about something else -- something the student knows well."

Q3 (Short answer) Soren says some people clean "enthusiastically" and he envies them. What does the word enthusiastically carry in this context -- is it just about energy, or is there something he's really envying?

Teacher tip: Let the student move beyond the surface definition. The word is doing more work here than "with energy" -- Soren is contrasting two whole relationships with a task. Wait for the student to feel that contrast before offering any response.

If the student struggles: Ask: "What's the opposite of Soren's experience of cleaning? He says 'no ceremony, no buildup' -- what does that tell us about what enthusiastically really means for him?"

Q4 (Short answer) Soren calls his approach to housework "strategic planning." Is he using this phrase admiringly, neutrally, or critically? How can you tell?

Teacher tip: This is a register and tone question -- there's no single right answer, and the student may push back on the multiple-choice framing implied by "admiringly, neutrally, or critically." Let them. The quality of their reasoning matters more than the label they choose.

If the student struggles: Ask: "Strategic planning sounds like something from a business meeting. Does Soren sound proud of applying it to housework -- or like something went a bit wrong somewhere?"

Speaker -- Renata

I find that my mood swings around housework are -- actually kind of embarrassing to admit. Like, I'll come home and the place is a disaster and I'll feel this wave of something that's almost like grief, which sounds dramatic, but that's what it is. And then two days later I'll come home and it's exactly the same and I'll think, whatever, I'll sort it at the weekend. And I can't predict which version of me is going to walk through the door. What I've noticed is that my feelings about it intensify when I'm already under pressure from something else -- work, or something personal. It's like the mess isn't just the mess anymore, it becomes evidence of something. I don't always know what. And then -- this is the part I find hardest to explain -- when I finally clean, and I mean really clean, there's a moment after where I feel like something has been taken off me. Not lifted off gradually. Just... gone. And I've come to appreciate that feeling, even if I forget it between times. It comes as a surprise every single time. Like I'd forgotten it was even available.

Stop and Think

Q1 (Short answer) Renata says that when she's under pressure, the mess "becomes evidence of something." What do you think she means -- evidence of what? And does the phrase to find yourself under pressure suggest she chose that state, or that it arrived without warning?

Teacher tip: This is a two-part question -- the first half is interpretive and open, the second half is a precision question about the phrase. Let the student take the interpretive part first; it will warm them up for the precision work. Resist supplying the answer to either part.

If the student struggles: Ask: "Does she say what the mess is evidence of? And if she doesn't know -- what does that tell us? And: if I said 'I found myself in a strange city,' did I plan to be there?"

Q2 (Multiple choice) Renata says it "comes as a surprise" every time she feels relief after cleaning. Which of the following best captures what this phrase tells us?

- a) She is surprised because the relief is stronger than she expected
- b) She knows the relief is coming but is still caught off guard by the feeling
- c) She has genuinely forgotten, each time, that cleaning makes her feel better**
- d) She is surprised because she doesn't think she deserves to feel better

Expected answer: c

Teacher tip: Options b and c are close -- and the distinction is worth sitting with. If the student chooses b, ask: "Is there a difference between knowing something intellectually and actually remembering how it feels? Which one does Renata seem to be describing?"

If the student struggles: Ask: "She says 'like I'd forgotten it was even available.' Does 'forgotten' sound like someone who knew it was coming -- or someone who genuinely lost access to the memory of it?"

Q3 (Short answer) Renata describes mood swings around housework. What does the word mood swing tell us about the nature of her feelings -- are they a response to what's actually happening around her, or something that moves more on its own terms?

Teacher tip: This is the counter-example question for this set. Let the student sit with it -- they may assume mood swings are always irrational or always caused by external things. Both are partially true for Renata. Hold space for a nuanced answer rather than a tidy one.

If the student struggles: Ask: "A mood swing moves in two directions. Is Renata in control of when it swings? And does the mess cause her feelings -- or does something inside her determine how she reacts to the same mess on different days?"

Q4 (Short answer) Renata says she has "come to appreciate" the feeling of relief after cleaning -- even if she forgets it between times. What does the word appreciate carry here -- is it the same as enjoying something, or is there a difference?

Teacher tip: Wait after asking. The distinction between appreciating and enjoying is subtle and productive at this level. Resist signalling which direction is correct -- let the student's reasoning lead.

If the student struggles: Ask: "Can you appreciate something that you also find difficult? Can you enjoy something without really thinking about it? Try applying both words to something the student knows -- something in their own life."

STAGE 3 -- COURSEBOOK BRIDGE | ~2 minutes

Teacher note: This should take no more than 2 minutes. The transition is intentional -- the student has spent the last 35 minutes thinking, reading, and talking about housework and their emotional relationship to it. They arrive at the text having already done the interpretive work. No further framing is needed beyond the line below.

STUDENT INSTRUCTION

Go ahead and open your book to page 30.

ICQ

ICQ Which page are you opening to?
Expected: Page 30

End of Teacher Version.